

just hold a window by the Windows Manager and shake it, and all the other windows minimise, leaving only that one. The sidebar is now gone, and has been replaced by gadgets directly on the desktop, *a la* Konfabulator and KDE4. They call it the Windows Gadget Platform. Aye, refer to the photo gallery on the previous page to find out more.

When you first boot up Mandriva 2009.1, you'll be forgiven for thinking that Mandriva is a visual disaster. The culprit is *La Ora*, the artwork stack of Mandriva, which makes it look like it's from the last century. We did some handiwork and switched our Mandriva back to KDE4's default look—Oxygen. It probably is a mere coincidence, but Windows 7s and KDE4's desktop look very similar: a transparent, big, iconised toolbar, widgets on the desktop... It's another co-incidence that Mandriva and Windows 7's default wallpapers represent a single fish in water. There are no glass borders on Mandriva, and the text won't look as good as on Windows (as subpixel rendering is patented by Microsoft as part of its ClearType technology). No Aero Shake as well. However, KWin's compositing effects (now enabled by default if a good enough GPU is found) cover much more effects than Windows 7. These effects are more soothing than the ones on Windows, but the total effect is lost because of the lack of enough transparencies. And while Windows makes your windows look like glass panels, KDE makes them look like, umm... better.

Another feature was wallpaper slideshows. KDE has it, but it'll cycle over all the wallpapers in your KDE wallpaper registry (or you can add your own 'Pictures' folders there). Over at Windows's stable, there are huge collections of high-resolution images grouped into categories, such as scenes, cartoons, nature, etc. You select one such category, and your wallpapers will cycle over images from it. A category (called a theme) will also change the window border hue (no colour, because it's transparent), and the sounds.

Hardware detection on Mandriva was typical of a Linux platform. Everything except our voice modem (it's a software modem, and thus Windows specific) and the

multimedia hotkeys on our keyboard was detected. Although our nVidia card was detected, drivers had to be downloaded from the Internet. That's because we're using the 'free' version, which means the DVD has only Free (as in freedom, not beer) software. The nVidia Forceware drivers are not free. But it wasn't at all hard to set it up, however. We could enter Mandriva Control Centre (Mandriva's Control Panel) and just start the X configuration tool, and it asked us that since there were proprietary drivers available, would we like to install them? We said, 'Yes', and after a few downloads and a logout later (no reboot, mind you—Linux doesn't need them), our 9400GT was working like a charm. The Mandriva 2009.1 Spring One Edition comes as a live CD and includes the proprietary drivers as well, so everything works out of the box.

Ratings	Windows 7	Mandriva 2009.1
Looks	10	7 (when we reverted to the default KDE4 look)
Responsiveness	7	8
Speed	6	8
Out of box hardware support	9	9
Overall user experience	8	6

Don't be fooled, however; Mandriva still looks a million times better than Windows XP.

Functionality

This is where all good things about Windows 7 come to an end. Let's see...

Windows 7 takes up an elephantine 6.5 GB space. It dumps everything on the hard drive, and then disables three quarters of all the features waiting for us to enable them. Gazillions of unused drivers lie on our hard drives, taking up space and slowing down the boot process. And at that amount of space consumption, we'd expect some goodies to come along with Windows. We were left shocked.

Apart from Windows Media Centre, Windows Media

